

Companion Virus

There are more methods of infecting a system other than the most commonly used one of modifying an existing file (see Parasitic Virus). Given the way command-line interpreters (or shells) of several operating systems work, a virus can copy itself onto the system as an entire program yet be sure that much of the time, attempts to invoke a program will result in the virus' code being run first. Such programs are known as companion viruses and there are several forms of this infection method.

Constructor Kit, Generator Kit

Some virus writers are not content with writing their own viruses and have wondered about bringing the 'opportunity' of becoming a virus writer to the masses. The solution to this is usually some form of 'construction kit'—a program even a non-programmer can run, feed some parameters into and then produce a virus.

Crack

Any software designed to modify other software for the purpose of removing usage restrictions. An example is a 'patcher' or 'patch generator' that will replace bytes at specified locations in a file, rendering it as good as a fully-licensed version.

Data Diddlers

Data Diddlers is a popular name for a virus that contains a data modifying payload. This type of virus may, for instance, change 0s to 9s in an MS Excel spreadsheet or it may even replace certain words.

Checksum

An identifying number calculated from file characteristics. The slightest change in a file changes its checksum. This is used to ensure that you have the exact same file as the one written by the author.

Clean, Disinfect

To remove a virus or other malicious software from a computer, file or disk.